

RESERVE NETWORK STUDY

One network across the whole reserve.

We modelled Amakhala's terrain from satellite elevation data and checked every radio path against it. two ridge high-sites and one short relay put 8 of the 8 lodges we could locate on clear radio paths, fed from a carrier uplink on Paterson high ground.

Prepared for

Richard, Amakhala Game Reserve

Prepared by

Gerhard Smit, CTTX Services (Pty) Ltd

Date

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--- Carrier uplink — Private backbone — Lodge link
 ■ Clear line of sight for a 3 m field terminal

Sentinel-2 imagery, 7 September 2026. The dotted outline is the study area around the lodges. Site positions are desktop candidates, to be confirmed on a site visit.

8 of 8

lodges on a clear,
Fresnel-checked radio
path

2 + 1

ridge high-sites plus
short relays

66%

of the 129 km² study
area in line of sight

17.1 km

clear carrier uplink into
the reserve

01

Where things stand today

Most lodges on Amakhala list Wi-Fi in the public areas by the main lodge, with each lodge sorting out its own connection. We propose a single backbone that

belongs to the reserve.

WHAT THE PUBLIC RECORD SHOWS

- Each lodge buys and manages its own service
- Wi-Fi is listed for the public areas by the main lodge
- Security, ecology and maintenance teams are not on a shared network
- Nothing links the gates, water points or fences

02

Carrier in, private network out

Carrier connectivity comes into the reserve once. Everything past that point runs on infrastructure the reserve owns.

LAYER 1 · CARRIER

Uplink from Paterson high ground

An uncontended business-grade Vodacom service, delivered by CTTX over a 17.1 km link to High Site North. LTE failover keeps the reserve connected if the carrier path drops.

LAYER 2 · BACKBONE

Ridge high-sites

High Site North (353 m) and High Site South (410 m) sit 4.5 km apart with a clear link between them. A short Safari relay serves a lodge the ridges cannot see. Each site runs on solar and lithium storage with remote monitoring, so the network stays up through load-shedding.

LAYER 3 · DISTRIBUTION

Every lodge and ops site

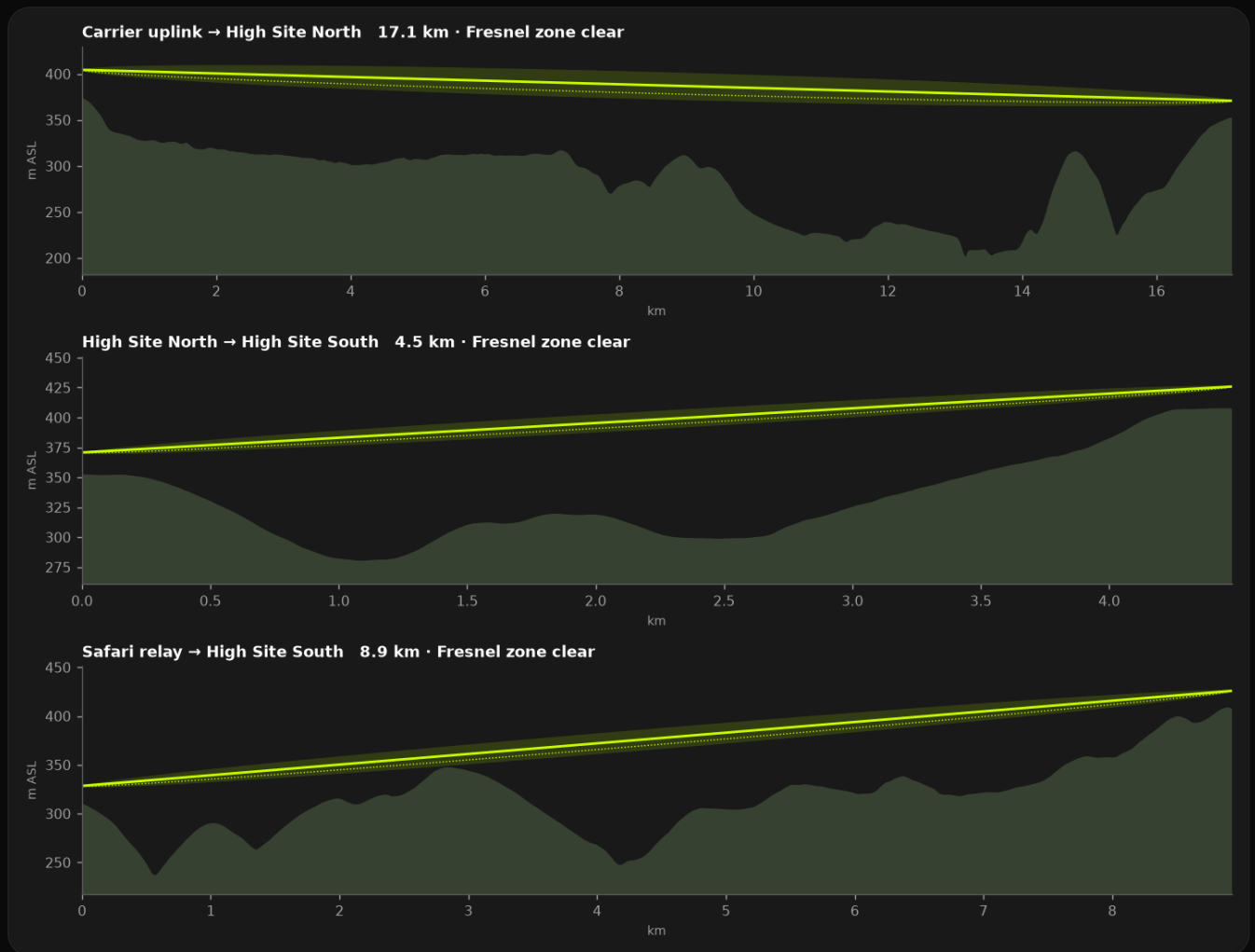
Sector radios reach the lodges, HQ, the anti-poaching base, ecology, the workshop and the gates. A LoRaWAN gateway is ready for fence, water-point, pump and fuel sensors.

BUILT FOR WHAT COMES NEXT

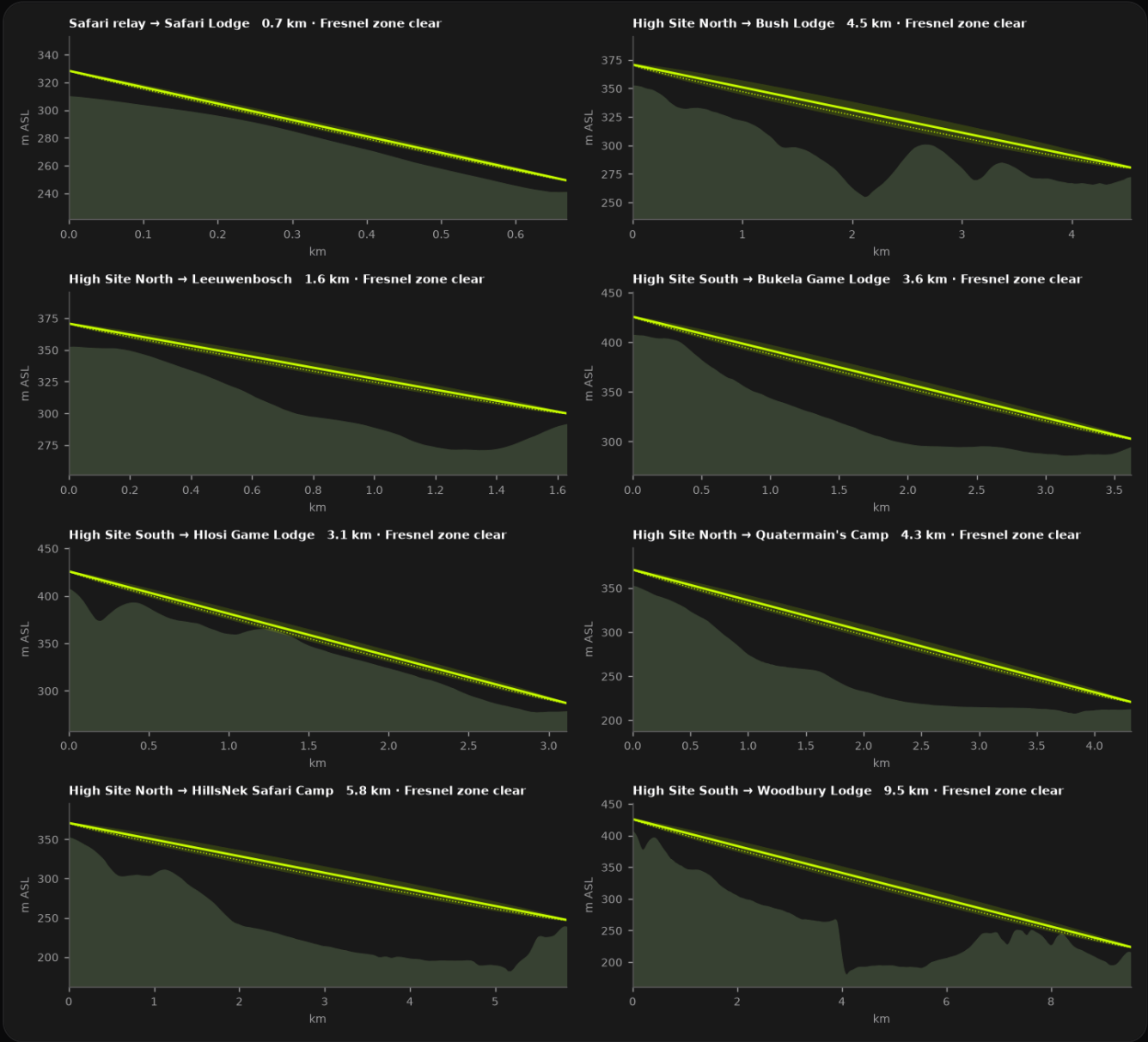
Once the backbone covers the reserve, a new camera, sensor or lodge is an endpoint on a network that is already there. It is not a new infrastructure project or a new provider contract.

03 Every path checked against the terrain

Each profile shows the ground between two sites, the radio path (lime line) and its Fresnel zone (lime band). We allow for earth curvature and require at least 60% of the zone to be clear at every point. A path that fails is not drawn.



LODGE	SERVED FROM	PATH LENGTH	LINE OF SIGHT
Safari Lodge	Safari relay	0.7 km	CLEAR
Bush Lodge	High Site North	4.5 km	CLEAR
Leeuwenbosch	High Site North	1.6 km	CLEAR
Bukela Game Lodge	High Site South	3.6 km	CLEAR
Hlosi Game Lodge	High Site South	3.1 km	CLEAR
Quatermain's Camp	High Site North	4.3 km	CLEAR
HillsNek Safari Camp	High Site North	5.8 km	CLEAR
Woodbury Lodge	High Site South	9.5 km	CLEAR



04

One backbone for every driver of the business

A reserve network carries three loads at once. This design is built to hold all three on one backbone.

GUEST EXPERIENCE

Reliable Wi-Fi, booking and card payments at every lodge.

STAFF COMMUNICATION

Lodges, HQ, rangers and maintenance on one network, day and night.

SECURITY AND OPERATIONS

Cameras, gates, fence alarms and sensors on the same backbone, powered through load-shedding.

05

What other properties got back

Sandymount Safaris 30,000+ ha, three lodges

BEFORE

A consumer wireless service at about 3 Mbps down and 8 Mbps up, with the provider on site daily to swap IPs and reinstall equipment.

AFTER

A Vodacom-backed 100 Mbps symmetrical link into the reserve, a CTTX-built main mast and two secondary masts, solar and lithium power, all monitored remotely.

GUEST EXPERIENCE

HD sport streams live at the lodges. Guest connectivity is no longer something the lodges think about.

STAFF COMMUNICATION

Over 800 Mbps measured across the reserve's own backbone, linking the main lodge, Mountain Retreat and Samar.

SECURITY AND OPERATIONS

Daily provider callouts went to zero. Every fault used to need a vehicle and a person; now the network is monitored remotely.

OWNERSHIP

The reserve keeps adding systems on top of the backbone. In the client's words, they stopped doing speed tests.

WHEN THE NETWORK GOES QUIET AFTER HOURS

Elephants broke out after 21:00 and staff had no effective way to coordinate. The requirement that came out of it: dependable communications after hours, across the areas where an incident can happen.

An Eastern Cape lodge near Addo

OWNING THE NETWORK PAYS FOR ITSELF

Replacing a rented, contended service and rented access points with a lodge-owned network roughly halves the monthly connectivity bill. Payback is modelled at about 14 months, and the network then covers areas the old setup never reached, including the spa.

The same lodge, modelled business case (26 Sep 2026)

What changes when the reserve owns it

TODAY

- Each lodge buys and manages its own service
- Wi-Fi is listed for the public areas by the main lodge
- Security, ecology and maintenance teams are not on a shared network
- Nothing links the gates, water points or fences

WITH A RESERVE BACKBONE

- One uncontended carrier feed shared across the reserve
- Lodges, HQ, the anti-poaching base and gates on one private network
- Coverage out into the field, day and night
- An owned asset that takes cameras and sensors without new towers

Avoided loss

Gate cameras, fence and trigger alarms, and after-hours communication for the Equine APU and K9 unit. When something happens at night, the right people know in minutes.

Operational efficiency

Water points, pumps and fuel tanks report their own status, so there are fewer vehicle trips just to check. Maintenance, ecology and lodges share one communications path.

Infrastructure ownership

High sites, backbone and power belong to the reserve. The network grows with the reserve instead of depending on each lodge's separate provider.

Executive risk reduction

Management gets live visibility of the network, cameras and sensors, and a record of operational diligence for owners, insurers and conservation partners.

Next steps

1

30-minute call

Your peak usage, the incidents that were hardest to coordinate, and what currently needs a vehicle trip to check.

2

Confirm the sites

A marked map of HQ, the anti-poaching base and the gates. We add them to the model and rerun the link plan.

3

One day on the reserve

We walk the high sites and relay points, and confirm the carrier uplink with Vodacom.

4

Design and proposal

A final design in Cambium LINKPlanner, with equipment, power, a phased plan and the investment case.

Method. Terrain: Copernicus DEM GLO-30 (30 m). Imagery: ESA Sentinel-2 L2A true colour, 7 September 2026. Radio model: 5.8 GHz, effective earth radius factor 4/3, 60% first-Fresnel-zone clearance at every point. The terrain model does not include trees or buildings. Every path is confirmed on survey before anything is built.

Candidate positions. High Site South -33.56661, 26.07792; High Site North -33.52632, 26.08093; Safari relay -33.49751, 26.02860; carrier uplink -33.41625, 25.95175 (Paterson high ground). The exact carrier site is subject to Vodacom feasibility.

Gerhard Smit

CTTX Services (Pty) Ltd

Tel 084 550 3281

Email gerhard@cttx.co.za

Web cttx.co.za